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Distant Reading ENGE5340

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Reconstruing Narration through Space: A Comparative Study of *The Iliad* and *The Silence of the Girls*

1. Introduction

Space is not a neutral background in myth; it is closely related to power and narrative position. In contemporary female myth retellings, the reconfiguration of space successfully “slants” the narrative center of Homeric epic towards the embodied experience of women (Zajko 48), thus allowing “Homer’s works [to tell] about women’s experiences and concerns” (Theodorakopoulos and Cox 2).

As Doreen Massey observes, “Spaces and places are not only themselves gendered but [...] reflect and affect the ways in which gender is constructed and understood” (179). By comparing how different texts organize the dwelling and the movements of characters, it can be identified how narrative emphasis occurs through structural shift.

This project focuses on this spatial shift between *The Iliad* and *The Silence of the Girls* (henceforth SOG), exploring how the redistribution and refinement of space tilt the focus of narration in SOG, in which the original plot structure remains. In this project, distant reading techniques of R are applied to encode and compare spatial elements across texts to identify how the space differs in the form of the creation of

new space and the movements of the characters. This approach provides a new perspective with the help of methods that are not often considered in literary analysis while transcending text structure (Moretti 77).

In terms of translation, this project adopts Emily Wilson's translation of *The Iliad* (2023). Initially, Samuel Butler's version was considered, but in the actual comparison, it was found that the spatial terms in Butler's translation are relatively general. Wilson's translation is more suitable for this study because of its clear distinction of spatial distinction, which supports the detailed analysis of the camp interior and battlefield location.

It is also necessary to clarify that the timelines of the two works do not fully overlap. The narrative time of SOG is significantly longer than that of *The Iliad*. It starts from the destruction of Briseis's country to the death of Achilles, while *The Iliad* starts from the conflict between Agamemnon and Achilles over Briseis to the end of Hector's funeral. Therefore, the comparison cannot be based on the absolute simple numbers. This project will focus more on the proportional model.

2. Generating Female Space: The Concentration of Tent

This section seeks to verify whether the tent in SOG converges from a broader camp term in *The Iliad* to a more specific and stable spatial node, and thus becomes an important site for generating female space. This section will compare the textual distribution and semantic environment of "tent", in order to examine the change of its spatial function in *The Iliad* and SOG.

At the level of close reading, it is already possible to sense that “tent” does not belong to the same spatial context in *The Iliad* and SOG. To test this semantic difference preliminarily, the semantic cluster map drawn by UMAP is useful for identifying the words closest to “tent” in the two texts. The purpose of **Figure 2.1** is to examine whether “tent” depends on a similar semantic environment in the two works.

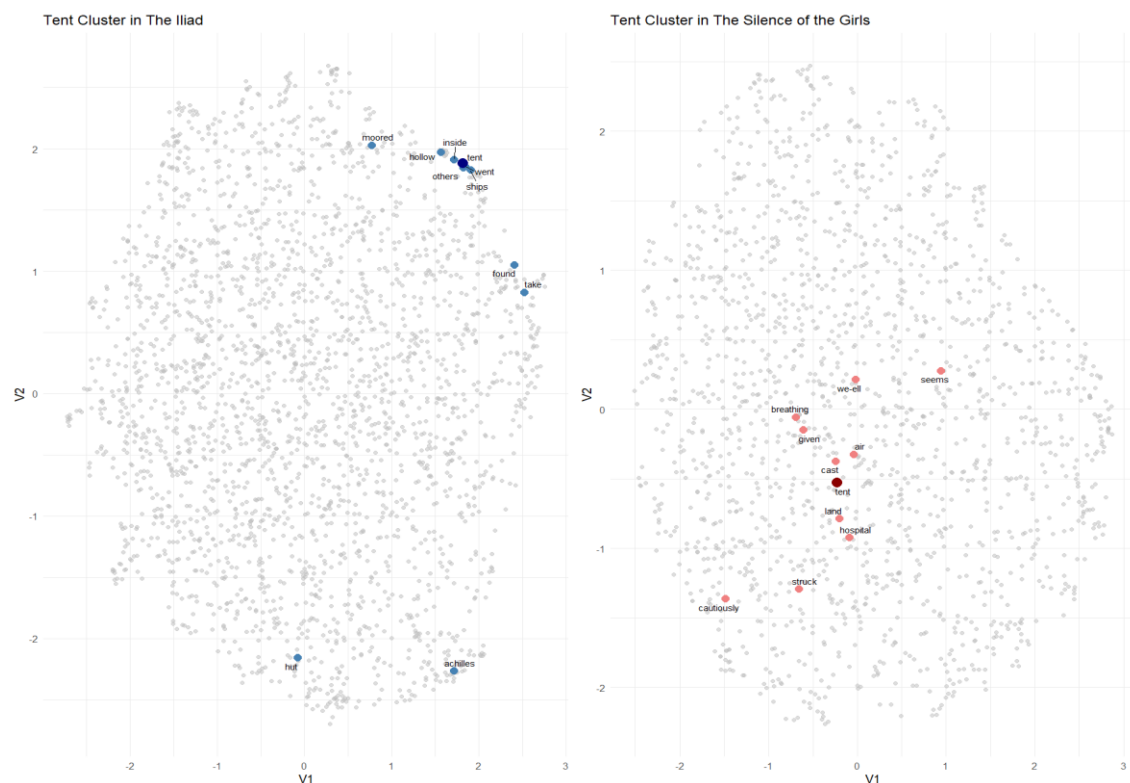


Figure 2.1 UMAP visualization of semantic clusters around “tent” in *The Iliad* and SOG

Figure 2.1 shows that the words closest to “tent” in *The Iliad* include “ships”, “moored”, “inside”, “hut”, indicating that it mainly belongs to shore-side stationing and the residential space part of the camp. In SOG, words such as “hospital”, “air”, “breathing” are more obviously semantically similar to “tent”, indicating that it has been drawn into a more internal space and closer to bodily experience, rather than a broader conception of residence.

To test this assumption, the lexical dispersion plots show their distributional positions within each text (**Figure 2.2**). “Battlefield” is included as a reference item since it remains a space that excludes women in both texts.



Figure 2.2 Lexical dispersion of “tent” and “battlefield” in *The Iliad* and SOG

In *The Iliad*, the distribution of “tent” is relatively loose, appearing in different sections across the text. Together with “battlefield”, “tent” constitutes the general spatial vocabulary in the “camp-frontline” structure. However, SOG presents a different image. “Tent” is more concentrated in the middle section of the text, rather than the continuous appearance of “battlefield” throughout the whole text. This aggregation shows that in SOG, “tent” is more concentrated than in *The Iliad*, and is more likely to cluster around particular narrative segments. Therefore, it may have shifted from a relatively broad camp term into a more specific functional space.

On this basis, UDPipe and POS tagging are used to extract relevant nouns from

sentences containing “tent”, using lemma as a statistical unit to explore the nouns that make up the narrative of space in the tent. Then, a word cloud is used to visualize the result (**Figure 2.3**).



Figure 2.3 A word cloud of 69 nouns collocating with “tent” in SOG extracted by UDPipe and POS tagging (top frequent lemmas)

Figure 2.3 demonstrates that the most frequent nouns around the tent include “hospital”, “bandage”, “blood”, “herb”, etc. It reveals the continuous connection between tent and healing, nursing, and bodily sensation.

This word cloud (**Figure 2.3**) should be further discussed through a manual classification of the KWIC results of “tent” in SOG (**Figure 2.4**). After extracting the contexts in which tent appears in SOG, the surrounding keywords were grouped into several semantic categories. It helps explain why the lemma “man” frequently appears in the semantic space of tent (**Figure 2.3**), though the space is still predominantly

shaped by the production of women. The lemma “man” mainly refers to those wounded or dying Greek soldiers who needed to be tended by women. In SOG, the care of the wounded and the dead becomes a specific form of women’s labor, to such an extent that Achilles himself is refused when he wants to wash Patroclus’ body (Barker 244). By contrast, in *The Iliad*, healing is mainly assigned to men, such as Patroclus. Also, the space of healing is not organized around a fixed location like the “tent” in SOG.

Medical Care	hospital	wounded	bandages	blood
Bodily Sensation	thick	stained	scrape	heat
War	battle	trojans	news	hope
Enclosure	entrance	back		

Figure 2.4 Manually annotated semantic categories of keywords co-occurring with *tent* in SOG, based on the KWIC results of “tent”

Therefore, this set of explorations can jointly support the following conclusion: the “tent” in SOG shifts from the broader meaning of camp space in *The Iliad*. With its concentrated appearance in specific sections and the surrounding noun field, the “tent” gradually acquires a more specific spatial property. It begins to carry the function of healing and nursing, embodied sensation produced by female experience, thus becoming a more stable and more discussion-worthy spatial unit. The “tent” can be an important piece of evidence for generating a new female space in SOG. It shows that the novel reorganizes the spatial function within the camp, which allows female experience to gain greater visibility in the originally male-dominated world of war, though the war outcome or gender order are not changed.

3. Reorganizing Mobility: Briseis and Achilles

This section examines whether *The Iliad* and SOG differ significantly in their organizational modes of movement, and how this difference redirects narrative focus towards female experience. It focuses on comparing the different spaces that characters enter during narrative progression.

The first step is to segment SOG by sentence. The reason why it is not cut up into chunks is that the grammatical logic of the original sentence is very important to the space. Then `str_detect()` is used for matching the sentence numbers, and `filter()` is used to retain spatial terms that genuinely function as spatial nodes, such as hut, compound, camp, ship, shore, hall, etc. Then, these sentences are sorted into two layers of spatial information through manual annotation. The first layer is macro-space, which is a large spatial hierarchy, such as Lyrnessus (**Figure 3.1; Figure 3.2**) / battlefield (**Figure 3.4; Figure 3.5; Figure 3.6**), camp, sea. The second layer is precise space, referring to more specific nodes. A general category, such as “hut” or “ship”, would be insufficiently precise since Achilles’s hut and Agamemnon’s hut definitely carry different spatial meanings. Therefore, the subsequent sub-level distinguishes between spaces such as Achilles’ hut, the women’s huts, Ajax’s compound, and Nestor’s hut, for identifying the specific space belonging to each character. In the visualization process, each precise space is assigned a fixed coordinate point, and these precise spaces are placed under their corresponding macro-spaces. Finally, the fixed points were connected according to sentence order through a line chart, producing a movement map. To ensure that all space labels are included and that the visualization figures remain tidy, the horizontal

axis is evenly spaced. This arrangement makes it possible to read the spatial positions and the movement trajectory at the same time, particularly transitions across macro-spaces. However, accommodating all labels inevitably results in reduced label size. To improve readability, each figure of SOG is accompanied by a supplementary version that retains the three spatial levels but relocates the labels to the vertical axis, making the names of precise spaces easier to read (**Figure 3.2; Figure 3.5**). However, the horizontal axis in the supplementary version can only represent the sequence of the character and spatial items rather than the original sentence order. For this reason, the two figures are worth reading altogether.

The same process is used in *The Iliad*, though, because of the poetic form of the text, the horizontal axis adopts the sequential serial number of instances in which the selected character and spatial term appear together. For this specific reason, the figures based on different texts cannot be directly merged into a single figure. Nevertheless, they share the same set of vertical axis hierarchy and therefore still provide a clear comparative basis.

In **Figure 3.1**, as discussed above, the horizontal axis indicates the order of Briseis in narrative progression, and the vertical axis indicates which layer of macro-space she enters, with the specific location under this layer as small labels. This figure can answer two questions at the same time: first, in which macro-spaces is her main activity; second, what specific nodes are composed of these macro-spaces. This figure shows a clear structure. The opening stage of movement is concentrated in the Lyrnessus layer, which is connected with Briseis's life before being taken as a war prize. Soon, Briseis's later

spatial experience is almost entirely compressed under the macro-spatial hierarchy of the camp.

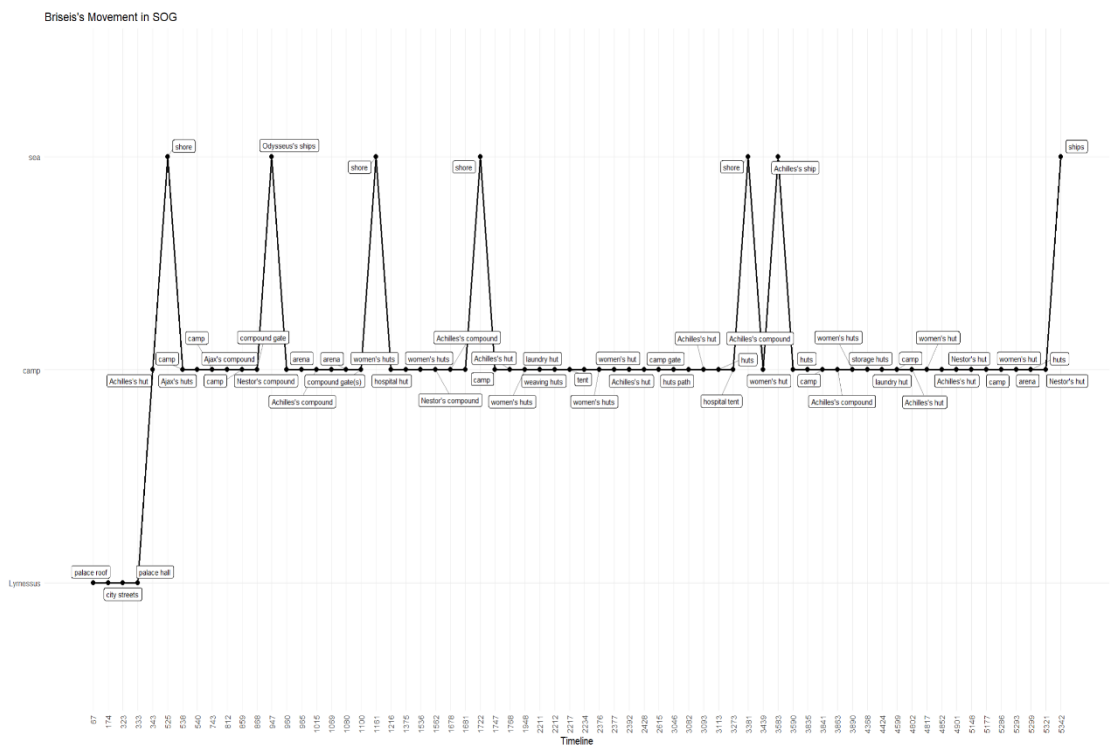


Figure 3.1 Briseis’s movement trajectory across macro- and micro-spatial levels in SOG, illustrating transitions between Lyrnessus, camp, and sea, and their associated smaller units, which are included in the macro space

Figure 3.2 demonstrates that the interior of the camp is subdivided into multiple nodes: Achilles’s hut, Achilles’s compound, women’s huts, Nestor’s huts, etc. It can be seen that her movement is organized between a series of specific nodes within the camp framework. Moreover, SOG splits the camp into more nodes with functional differences, such as storage huts, the hospital tent, and the laundry hut. These different and detailed locations do not change the fact that Briseis’s mobility remains confined in the camp, but they bring greater focus to the daily space she experiences. The precise spaces inside the camp are named and expanded one by one through her perspective. Besides, the

spaces at the level of the sea are also endowed with different meanings by Briseis' own experience.

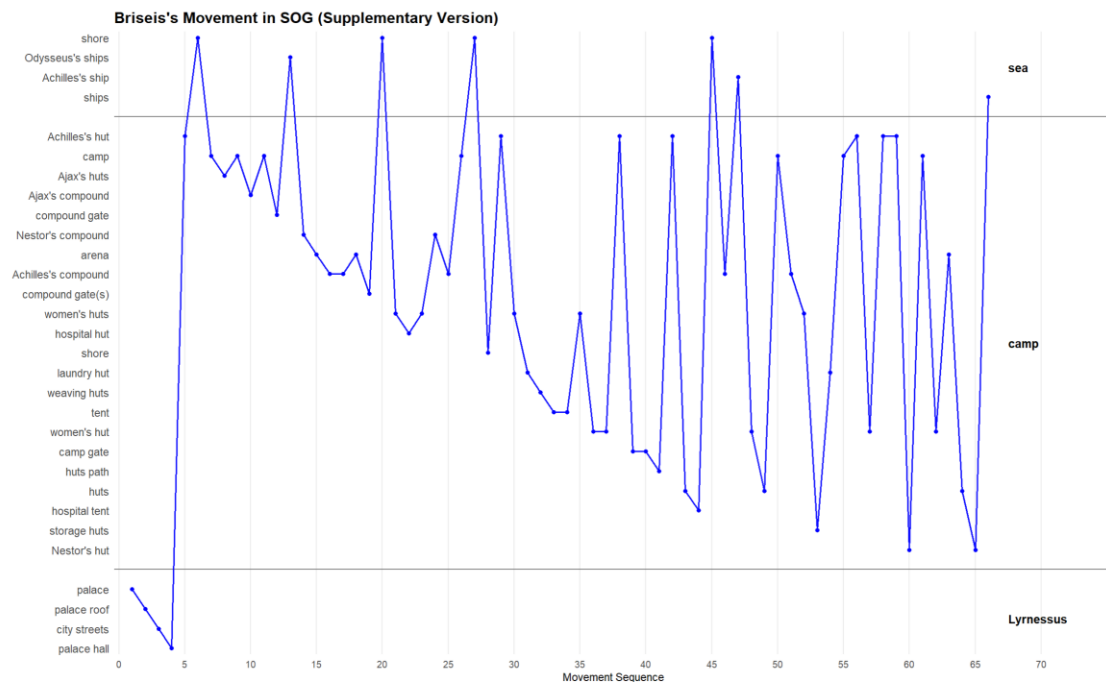


Figure 3.2 The supplementary version of Briseis's movement trajectory (blue) of SOG

As shore, sea, and ships appear repeatedly on **Figure 3.1** and **Figure 3.2**, making sea a recognizable space outside the camp, providing a brief and fragile space of freedom in her confined camp life. As a result, the text makes the confinement perceivable and also analyzable. The narrative center of SOG also undergoes a structural shift toward the spatial experience and embodied experience of female characters.

Figure 3.3 shows Briseis's movement in *The Iliad*. Whether compared to Achilles' movement (**Figure 3.6**) in the same text, or the same character's movement in SOG (**Figure 3.2**), the spatial visibility of Briseis in *The Iliad* is obviously much lower, which

can be seen from the number of nodes.

In *The Iliad*, Briseis's spatial position serves the power logic of male heroic narrative. Her movement is organized through transfers between male-owned spaces. She flows between a small number of male-owned locations. Her mobility is related to possession and ownership confirmation. The internal structure of the camp also appears simple. The distinctions between precise spaces mainly derive from different ownerships, and there is no functional usage classification of precise spaces, which can also be verified in **Figure 3.6**.

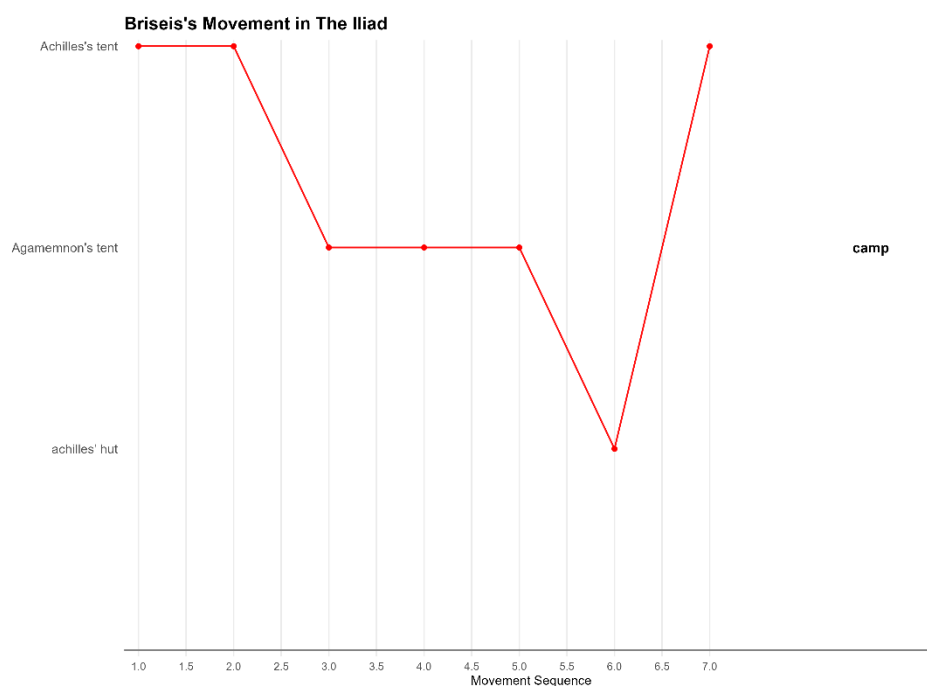


Figure 3.3 Briseis's movement trajectory (red) in *The Iliad*, illustrating her movement solely in the level of the camp

The same visualization logic is also applied to a comparison of Achilles' movement in the two texts. The results indicate that the storyline of Achilles in *The Iliad* and SOG remains the same, but his spatial movement and spatial proportion in different texts are different. Also, the different characters in the same texts can point to the spatial turn

developing in mythical reception.

A comparison of movement trajectories and space labels of Briseis (**Figure 3.1**) and Achilles (**Figure 3.4**) in SOG can also demonstrate the gendered spatial dynamics through space. Different from multiple precise spaces in the camp layer of Briseis's movement (**Figure 3.1**), the nodes that recur most frequently in Achilles's camp movement are Achilles's compound, Achilles's hut, yard, and gate (**Figure 3.4**). His movement tends to revolve around a relatively small set of core locations, rather than repeatedly passing through a wide variety of functionally differentiated spaces, as Briseis's does. In principle, these functional spaces are fully accessible to Achilles, though he rarely enters them, as they are more closely associated with women through forms of daily labor such as laundry and weaving. This distribution of space implies that the voluntary rejection of entering a space can also be rendered as a form of privilege.

Figure 3.4 demonstrates that in SOG, the proportion of the battlefield in Achilles's overall movement trajectory is significantly reduced compared to *The Iliad* (**Figure 3.6**). Together with **Figure 3.5**, they show that Achilles returns to the camp layer more frequently, and the inside of the camp is further divided into more specific nodes, including space categorized by ownership and also by functions. In SOG, Achilles's spatial experience is shaped more by mundane camp settings, which may indicate that the text portrays him on the human side by emphasizing his embodied experiences.

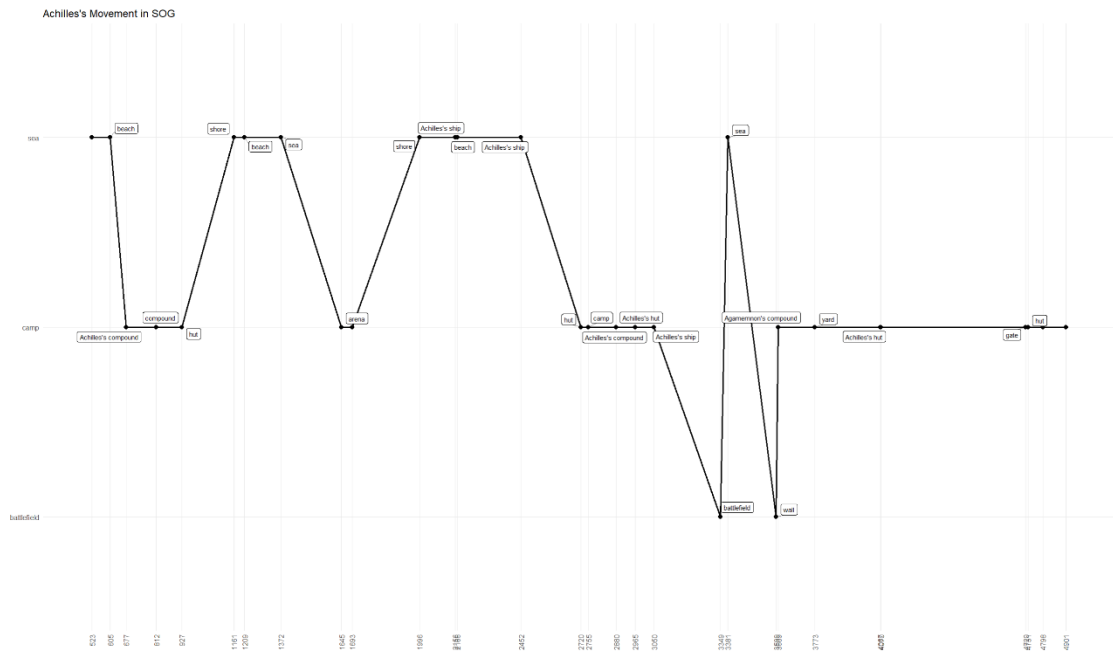


Figure 3.4 Achilles's movement trajectory across macro- and micro-spatial levels in SOG, illustrating transitions between battlefield, camp, and sea, and their associated smaller units

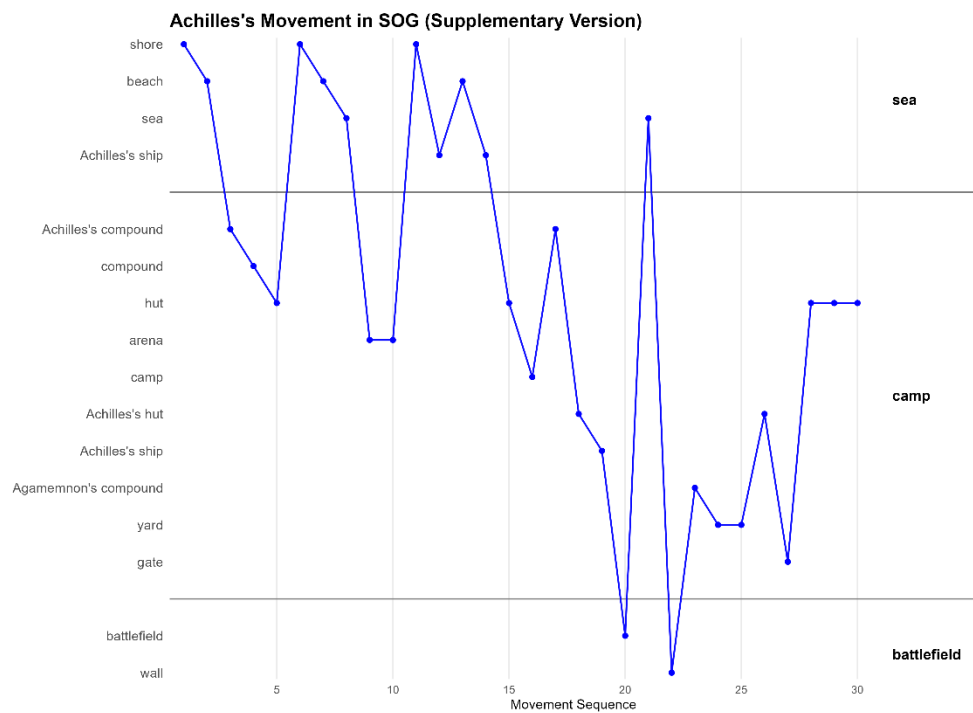


Figure 3.5 The supplementary version of Achilles's movement trajectory (blue) of SOG

However, *The Iliad* presents a different structure. Comparing **Figure 3.5** and **Figure 3.6**, Achilles's movement falls on the battlefield layer more proportionally than SOG, indicating that battlefield space occupies a higher proportion in a higher proportion than in SOG. Also, the movement of Achilles in *The Iliad* mainly unfolds between two sets of space. One is the frontline space formed by the battlefield, plain, and the Troy wall, and the other is the shore-side stationing space formed by ships and tents.

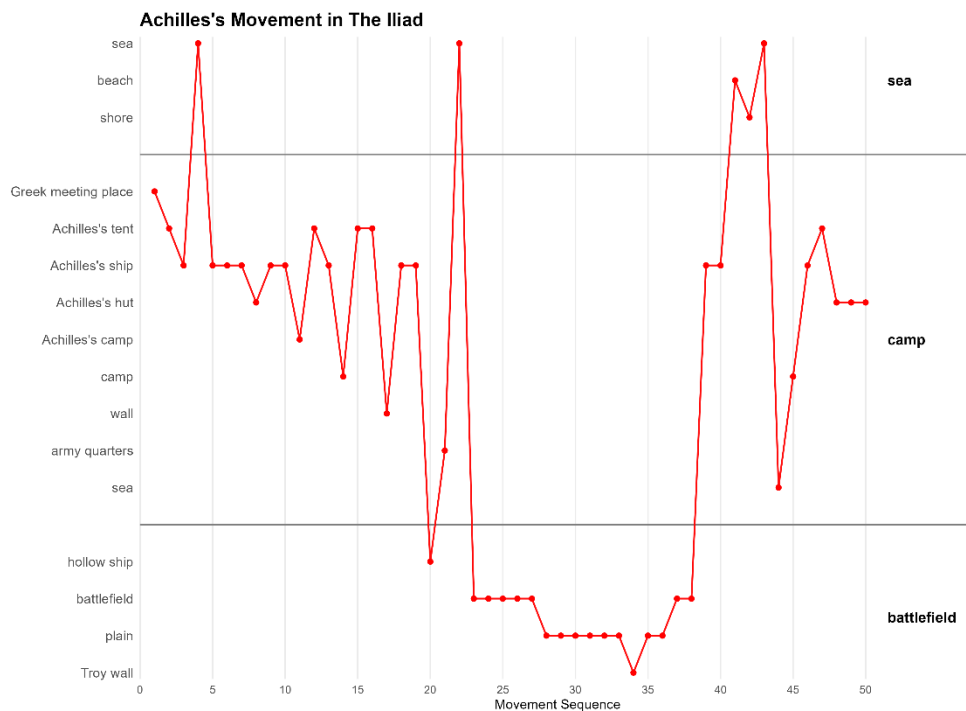


Figure 3.6 Achilles's movement trajectory (red) in *The Iliad*, illustrating his movements between three levels

This suggests that the two works organize androcentric narrative space differently. As an epic written from the third-person omniscient perspective, *The Iliad* views war as an important plot, which makes the battlefield a central narrative space. SOG, as a first-person narrative of Briseis, who has been confined in camp for a long time, will

naturally transfer more narrative attention to the camp interior, whether to herself or the characters around her. The difference in the narration space of Achilles in those works also demonstrates that SOG has offset the spatial center of the male characters in *The Iliad*. It suggests that the space of male characters should be examined when discussing gender dynamics through the space.

4. Conclusion

Although Briseis confesses in SOG that, “Looking back, it seemed to me I’d been trying to escape not just from the camp, but from Achilles’ story; and I’d failed.” (Barker 266), this project suggests that she has not failed.

Owing to limitations of length and time, many possible methods of inquiry remain unexplored. These might include trajectory analysis of additional characters, such as Patroclus, or another female character, such as Tecmessa.

This project also has its limitations. Quantitative encoding of spatial-gender attributes through R inevitably risks re-labeling space, reinforcing binary classifications such as public/private or freedom/confinement, and diminishing spatial fluidity and ambiguity, which is worth further critical examination.

This is especially true in the case of *The Silence of the Girls*, which is based on Briseis, a character who is already highly marginalized in *The Iliad*. Comparative research on the space between the retelling and the source text often resembles an argument about the production of the “tent” as a newly differentiated space in Section 2. The same cases, such as “loom” as a space of production, would fall into the same

pattern.

In summary, this project offers a comparative analysis of *The Iliad* and *The Silence of the Girls* from the perspective of distant reading, which also addresses the methodological concerns that may arise from relying on close reading alone. Through the examination of the production of new space and the comparison of character movements and spatial hierarchy, it is possible to see more clearly that space is reoriented toward women's experience in *The Silence of the Girls*, altering the narrative structure of *The Iliad*.

Works Cited

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